Future essays on this website will look slightly different. I am in the process of implementing a version history so viewers can see how an essay or a reflection has changed over time. Essays will now contain a slider that lets you move backwards through previous versions, alongside an option to highlight what changed.

Most writing I've encountered whether on blog websites similar to this one, or academic papers presents itself as though it arrived fully formed. There are many interesting drafts that get discarded and lost to the sands of time, deemed unworthy of final publication. I think these older drafts can be revealing and important too. Aside from lexical and grammatical changes, the narrative has natural perturbations as new evidence and ideas get folded into the discussion.

In my opinion, there is also value in presenting a half-finished idea which can later be revisited. Not everything has to be polished with clear conclusions, most of the time actually it is unclear where to go and the development takes time. Also, some ideas only become interesting once they've been shared. A conversation, a paper sent to you or an unexpected disagreement can change the direction and waiting until everything feels complete often means those ideas are never written down at all.

I've become more cognisant of this during my Master's. Throughout the year I tried to stay on top of writing small sections and paragraphs based on what I was doing at the time, in hopes that when I get to the write up at the end it will be easier to string my ideas together. Looking back through these old drafts reveals times I completely misunderstood something or an assumption I hadn't questioned. More commonly, the changes are subtle. An argument becomes a little more nuanced or a sentence becomes less certain. These changes are the honest record of how thinking develops and the finished product fails to capture this process. I've come to appreciate that knowledge is rarely static. Scientific understanding evolves through revision. Clinical practice changes as new evidence emerges. Good research is built on the willingness to revisit old conclusions in the light of better information.

This website has always been an experiment in capturing my thoughts and opinions at different points of time and how what I read and do influences them. This change attempts to become more consistent with the website's goal and also encourage me to write more without being worried about a final product. If you revisit an essay, you may find that it has changed. More importantly, you'll be able to see how it changed and the older versions will become part of the story. Because the process of arriving at a conclusion is often just as interesting as the conclusion itself.